

Who Am I and What Is My Name

On Image, Inwardness, and Inauthenticity

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There is a built-in gap between how a person behaves in society and how he behaves in solitude. Society constitutes a different kind of self-consciousness, one concerned with the reflection of the person and his behaviors in the awareness of those around him. In solitude, by contrast, consciousness is often "cleaner" of such image-reflection — a person can be more devoted to concerns and matters of the heart that belong to him exclusively and intimately, without having to account for them, without "wasting" attention on "what will they say" and "how does this look."

This gap often gives rise to a dilemma we might call "the problem of authenticity," or, in certain contexts, hypocrisy. When a person begins to pay closer attention to how he behaves in society, he often finds that this behavior does not honestly represent who he is — there is something in it that is put-on, false. Some suddenly notice that their social behavior is forcedly lighthearted, far beyond their true character; others feel that within the social encounter some dim inner force pushes them to be more assertive — to stand out, to be funny, to be heard — a force that, on inner reflection, does not seem to express anything deep in their personality; some become more refined in company, while others don a mask of a rougher, more "masculine" and cynical character; and so on. Sometimes a person feels that different social circles pull him in different, even opposite, directions. The moment this awareness surfaces — whether through self-examination done once the person is alone again and "clear-headed," or through some inner reflective glance that catches him in the midst of his "social" behavior and suddenly pulls him back to who he is in solitude — a somewhat jarring sense of fraud arises: I am lying, I am putting on a front, this is not who I really am.

When the "solitary" behavior is — in moral and spiritual terms — better than the "social" one, the feeling is a relatively mild one of falseness and inauthenticity; it is simply a weakness, a yielding to social pressure. But when the social behavior is better and more correct than the solitary one, that sets off much stronger alarm bells within us — "hypocrisy!" The difference reveals that we identify our truth, who we are at the hard, foundational core of our identity, with the "solitary" identity. Who I am and how I am when alone represents, for me, my honest essence, while my conduct under the pressure of society and image is driven by external motives that are merely part of my shell, of my outer wants; they do not express the inner core, the inwardness, what I truly am and what I truly want. And indeed, in many respects this is a highly reasonable, intuitive identification. Gravity of thought, considered judgment, and concentrated inner listening to the thoughts and deep feelings of my heart are made possible in a far clearer and more lucid way when I

am alone with myself, only with myself. The quiet of solitude clarifies, in a more deliberate and unclouded manner, the voices within me, since the background noise of the pressures of honor and the conditioning of society do not pull me out of focus and disrupt my frequencies.

But the trouble is that this gap between "solitary" behavior and "social" behavior — however jarring it may be in certain respects, and even though it sometimes appears to us as weakness and as fakeness — is also natural and to be expected; it is almost impossible to eliminate. Even an honest, sincere person behaves a little differently in society, and even a person of firm character will sometimes lean a bit this way or that depending on which company he is in. The difference in inner tuning is not fully controllable; the very fact of being in company arouses in us tendencies and traits of a different sort, and a different kind of self-relation. How can we judge ourselves harshly for a trait that appears to be a basic and natural feature of human experience?

If I return to the term I used above, society arouses in us an "image-reflection" — an awareness of how we look and how we are assessed and judged by the people around us. Being among other human beings constitutes, as it were, a thin additional layer of consciousness, concerned with our reflection in the eyes of others. I think that if we internalize this human experience as a basic one, if we understand that image-reflection generates a powerful force of will and make our peace with that fact, we can arrive at a certain solution to the problem of hypocrisy and draw out of this life-force blessing and good. Indeed, it matters to us how we are perceived in society; and however much we may claim to ourselves that this reflects fakeness and a lack of wholeness with the self, it is a force that cannot be ignored. So instead of denying it, I propose that we aim at it deliberately from the outset, and thereby govern this tendency with full awareness.

That is to say: everyone should hold before his eyes a positive image for his social self, the image he attempts to "play" and to which he aspires in society, the constant mask he strives to wear. This image ought to be built, above all, from good character traits. It should also reflect his truth, who he genuinely wants, with all his heart, to be. Between these last two statements there need be no contradiction; apart from the indifferent or the wicked, everyone genuinely wants to possess good character. The conscious decision to shape my "image" in a way directed toward an ideal type of person — a whole and good person — is the best way of grappling with the problem of fakeness and of surrendering to social norms. Instead of fighting the basic life-force behind my caring about how people see me, I choose to tune that very same force in the most direct and conscious way, so that it, too, will suit my deep inner will — the will to be good.

In this we may have solved the problem of the "soft" faker, the one whose social behavior is lower than his solitary behavior, the one who understands that his true "self" resides in a higher and better place, and that it is only the outward, image-conscious awareness that blocks this "self" from being realized. But we have not solved the harder problem — what justifies putting on a righteous, "perfect" mask, when my actual state is not so? Is this not

deceit? Is not the very use of an "image-social" will-force in order to appear as a good person itself hypocrisy?

Hypocrisy is a gap between the inner and the outer. But when the principle that constitutes the outer — that is, the basic definition of the content of the image a person wishes to build for his "social self" — matches his deep, sincere and true will also within his "solitary self" (even if not always the actual realization of that deep will), there is no longer justification for this accusation. The mere existence of a mask, the mere gap and separation between the two worlds, the mere psychic motivation that arises from the social self-image a person wishes to acquire for himself, is nothing to be ashamed of; it is simply the lot of the human being by the nature of his creation. Who I want to be is also how I want to be perceived — as a good, whole, upright, principled person, God-fearing, warm, of fine character. And who I want to be is the deepest, most correct and truest definition of who I am.

Our desire to appear good and to be perceived as good is not, in itself, an illegitimate desire, if this "good" is a high good, a true good. The constant social mask a person wears among others becomes part of who he is, exactly as a garment a person chooses to wear all the time already becomes a distinguishing mark and character trait of his; the question of how you aim to be perceived in your environment is part of your identity — indeed a deep and central part, since social life occupies a great weight and measure of the dimensions of our lives.

Moreover: the ability to cling always — at least for the lion's share of my time, when I am in the company of others — to the fine image I seek to establish for myself is no less difficult, and no less worthy of appreciation, than the ability to direct myself by personal, intimate values alone. After all, a person is measured by his deeds, by how he presents himself; and if he indeed strives for and clings to the "ideal" image he weaves for himself — even if the driving force is also the wish to be valued and judged by his surroundings, generally, as a good and quality person, by way of this clinging and effort to overcome the bad within him and realize the good — then that social judgment is justified, and the image is not hypocrisy.

Of course, there remains an obligation to try to narrow the practical gap between our behavior alone and our behavior before the eyes of others. The wish to narrow this gap stems, first of all, from the inner wish itself to be good always, but also from the wish to be honest, the wish not to be a fraud in one's own eyes. But the feeling of fraudulence is justified and desirable only insofar as it sharpens and strengthens the good will. In itself, it is not a reason to change our pattern of behavior in a place where we are, in fact, closer to our ideal of wholeness. In a certain sense it is not even entirely fair — for every person contains such a gap, which, as we said, is essential and almost unavoidable, and so, even though the social signal is, as it were, of a good and whole person, it is clear that within that signal lies an unspoken inner reservation: I am not truly whole, this does not constitute the whole of me, this is only who I seek to be.

This is not about accepting the psychic force of the pursuit of honor as it is. The elevation of the tendency to pursue honor consists in this: that I wish to receive appreciation not for

illegitimate things, and not for trivial things, but only for things that are truly part of who I am. The character traits I put on in company are the very same traits I make efforts to put on out of my authentic, deep will, the one that exists when I am with myself alone. I want people to appreciate me for the true quality that is in me, and to recoil from any popularity or honor I might receive from the shallow dimensions of society and of others. Here, too, lies a meaningful point of choice: do I prefer to be someone valued in society on the basis of skills, of external sociability and other trivial traits deemed popular, or do I wish to earn appreciation precisely from the higher, more substantial and profound sides of others — the sides that are moved by kindness of heart, uprightness, righteousness and strength of spirit.

The higher and truly better, the more substantial and deeper the social image I wish to establish for myself, and insofar as this image reflects, at the same time, the sincerest wish of my heart — the more the familiar dichotomy breaks down between the dirty, illegitimate touch of "pursuit of honor" and the pure, personal-intimate will. The two strata of my personality are directed toward one and the same aim, the aim of self-improvement and wholeness. I want to be good, and I want to be "clothed" as such. The wish to be perceived as good cannot stand entirely on its own, its purpose is not exhausted within itself (and if it did stand entirely on its own, it would indeed be illegitimate, on account of hypocrisy); but the fact that it is a secondary will does not make it an illegitimate one — the existence of higher wills does not make the other wills base and bad.

(It is clear that the decisive point, the junction at which I examine whether I am a faker or not, lies at the collision between society and the good — that is, in the reality where I must be prepared to suffer measures of scorn and contempt in order to walk the path of the upright and the good. There, the two strata of my will come into conflict, and there rests the absolute obligation to place the hand of the deep, good will on top. But throughout most of life, and in life as a whole, there is no need for one stratum to defeat and subdue the other; from both we may draw to serve God.)

When the above dichotomy breaks down and the different consciousnesses intermingle — the positive forces of the person only gain.

But what is the deeper explanation for the breakdown of the dichotomy between the elevated social image and the heart's wish to be good? Do the two consciousnesses actually touch, or unite, at some point, or do they merely intermingle owing to their external resemblance (that is, their shared actual trajectory)? This question matters, because if, in their inner truth, the inner-good will and the image-good will remain two distinct wills, then the demand and inner striving to raise one above the other also remains; there remains the ideal picture of one whose inner will completely overpowers the existence of the image-will, and this picture crowds out the place of the image-will and, in effect, strives for its elimination. This purist striving narrows the ability to make ideal, unapologetic, wholehearted use of this will from the outset; it blocks the ability to live with it out of fullness and harmony.

In order to resolve this question, we must place our trust in a metaphysical view of things, one that attempts to explain the existential-psychic principles we know from life according to its own categories. I will try to offer such a metaphysical perspective on the matter before us.

What is it that is so powerful in social being? What draws our attention so forcefully to our social image, to the question of how other people look at us and think of us? I think the answer to these questions lies in the concept of tzelem Elohim — the image of God. My basic assumption is that the root of all human wills is cleaving to God, attachment to Him, longing for Him, the wish to rejoice in Him and that He rejoice in us. Hence there is within us a deep will to be desired by God. This will appears and clothes itself in us also in lower, more "indirect" wills. Human beings are a powerful and highly manifest appearance of the divine. The entire social side of a person, the great place and power this side holds in the soul, the energy it draws and arouses — all of it begins, at the root and secret of the matter, from the tremendous divine manifestation clothed in the images of God, in the concrete people, in the other. That is why we draw from society strength, encouragement, support, meaning; this is how we can explain the tremendous power of interpersonal concepts such as friendship, affection, jealousy, identification, popularity, insult, loneliness, shame, group-belonging, grace, love.

When we are "desired by most of our brethren," when society delights in us, when people see in us good, quality and light, we feel satisfaction, meaning and a sense of affirmation that is a kind of "divine approval" in miniature. This feeling, because of the power concealed within it, fills us, and we are drawn to it and seek it always.

Of course, explaining some power or tendency as a clothed manifestation of divine force (or of a "religious" will, that is, one directed toward and aspiring to the divine) does not yet constitute an ethical or spiritual endorsement of it. At bottom, every force in the soul can be explained this way, since there is no object in the world that does not constitute some revelation of God. But when we understand the strong divine root of social occurrence and being, we are better able to explain what happens in the "breakdown of the dichotomy" of consciousness discussed above.

When I direct my image toward the good, and aspire to receive appreciation from people for the fact that I am good and moral and a true servant of God, then I am, in effect, aiming at the highest point in my human other. I aspire that people grant me appreciation from the noblest place within them, from the place that values goodness, that admires greatness of spirit, that is moved by refined character, from the part of them that is in love with gentleness, with kindness, with humility, with sensitivity, with a warm countenance, with devotion, with righteousness, with love, with depth, with religiosity. So that, in fact, I wish to touch their soul, I seek to find favor in the eyes of the divine part within them. And between that and finding favor in the eyes of God Himself, the source of goodness and morality, the gap is small to the point of insignificance. This is the meaning of the union of consciousnesses, of the intermingling of the "image" consciousness with the "solitary" consciousness; and therefore, even though they remain, existentially, forever on two

separate planes, one can exist in both with a whole heart, a single heart — a heart ascending to God.

Until now I have spoken in praise of the social image, of preserving it and persisting in devotion to it. However, I wish to add a note of reservation.

Indeed, presenting a social mask of wholeness is a legitimate act, as I have tried to argue above. It is not, in itself, hypocrisy or fakery, and it is also not, apparently, arrogance, since part of that very wholeness consists in behaving with ease, with a warm countenance, with basic humility, with a sense of self-worth. But alongside its basic legitimacy, this is not always the wisest and best course. Because ultimately, the signal — even with the humility (whether it is a false, cloying humility, which certainly grates on those around, or whether it is sincere and simple) — is still one of wholeness, and in this there is some essential concealment that may, in the end, indeed contain an element of fakeness. What, then, is the relation between legitimate image-concealment and excessive concealment? It seems to me that the main answer lies in the question of setting — that is, in the nature of the social system in question.

The mask is legitimate where it is legitimate and expected to wear masks. But not every place where there are many people is equivalent to the general public sphere. The broad, open social zone is a place that cannot exist unless everyone brings themselves wrapped, dressed, thereby protecting both themselves and the shared space. But in a tighter, closer or warmer social environment, one ought to make the effort precisely to remove masks, to open up. A mask is, after all, a form of alienation, and the aspiration there is toward a revealing of the face, toward adding companionship and intimacy up to the point of being able to be exposed. Hence there is value in the deliberate exposure of my weaker side, the petty, the ridiculous, the unheroic, the marginal, even the flawed. Not necessarily full exposure, not laying everything out on the table in an exhibitionist and immodest way, but tuning the signal so that it lets out a little of my personal, concrete side, my incomplete side. In a certain sense, this is a greater humility: to know that the signal should not convey only the aspiration and the deep inner will, not only the vision of my "self," but also the present self, the one that exists right now, to give the sense that I am aware of it, that I see it, that it too is part of the definition of my self. My willingness to leave others chinks into my flawed self, out of self-deprecating humor and acceptance, out of sincerity and lightness, is a fitting self-contraction, one that draws the society around me to look at me not with excessive appreciation, and not with envy either, but with intimacy, with truth. The image of wholeness also produces in the other a sense of being crowded out; the good in me presses upon my other's own self-regard, makes it harder for him to stand in his own place. Only if we add humility and openness to the mask, only if we wink and remind our social surroundings from time to time that this is, after all, a mask, can we truly leave room for the other, can we bring a clean companionship, one that appreciates without pressure, that recognizes the good in me without needing to defend itself. Only then will we, too, truly be humble.